

Breaking the Firewall

Is a personal firewall the solution to all your security problems? Certainly not, as many reports would seem to suggest. For instance, there's a utility specifically targeting ZoneAlarm and ZoneAlarm Pro that stops ZoneAlarm if it is running, and prevents it from starting. Called ZoneMutex , this is just a small terminate-and-stay-resident (TSR) program. Previous versions of ZoneAlarm were also prone to an Nmap scan which was done using port 67 as the identified port (nmap -g67 -sS <IP address>). eWeek magazine also reported another crack for BlackICE Defender that allowed to get past the firewall. The same crack was supposed to work with other firewalls such as Norton also.

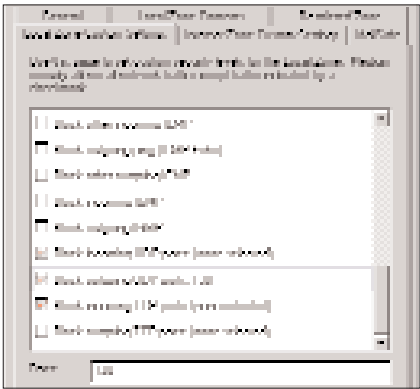
Remember that the effectiveness of a personal firewall is to a great extend

dependent on you and the rules you create. If a suspicious application tries to access the Internet, your firewall will most likely give a warning. Now, if you choose to allow this application access, then don't blame the firewall if the application turns out to be a Trojan. That's the main loophole most cracks for firewalls work around. It's the belief that if you are presented with an application that sounds familiar (say Explorer.exe or Iexplore.exe), you are most likely to give access to this application. It's therefore possible for a Trojan to rename itself as a known application and gain access to the system. Regularly monitor the activities of your firewall and use the NetWatcher utility that comes with Windows to check out your shares.

ports, and you can add other ports to monitor.

Tiny and ZoneAlarm Pro use the concept of blocking certain protocols on a range of ports. In both of these, you can select the protocol and the direction of

traffic you want blocked, and then the ports on which the firewall will listen to block the traffic. eSafe or BlackICE had the same features, but the difference was that you had to manually enter the information for each port.



Block protocols in ZoneAlarm Pro

McAfee was a bit different in terms of the protocols that it supported. While most firewalls restricted themselves to TCP and UDP, or added IGMP and ICMP, McAfee had support for allowing or blocking RIP (Routing Information Protocol), ARP, PPTP, etc. In terms of customising and ease of use, the simplest to use to block ports and protocols were ZoneAlarm Pro and Tiny.

Application-level security: The simplest way a firewall works is by restricting or granting permission to applications to access the Internet. The first time an application tries to access the Internet, the